

Dashboarding Tool Evaluation: Alternatives to Looker Studio

Action4Diabetes — Research Internship

CONFIDENTIAL — INTERNAL

1. Executive Summary

A note on naming — and what this report compares. Action4Diabetes currently uses **Looker Studio** (formerly Google Data Studio): Google's *free*, self-service dashboarding tool. This report treats Looker Studio as the **incumbent baseline** and scores it against the same criteria as the candidate replacements, so the gains (and losses) of switching are explicit rather than implied. Note that Looker Studio is a wholly separate product from **Looker (full)**, Google's *enterprise* BI platform built on the LookML semantic layer — they share a brand name but nothing else. Looker (full) was considered and set aside before scoring: its base platform alone runs roughly \$60K/year before per-seat fees, which is incompatible with an NGO budget, so it does not appear in the comparison. Where this report says "Looker Studio" it always means the current free tool.

This report evaluates four candidate tools — **Evidence**, **Metabase**, **Apache Superset**, and **Redash** — as replacements for Looker Studio in Action4Diabetes' research dashboarding workflow, each scored against Looker Studio as the incumbent baseline. The evaluation followed the four steps in the internship scope: surfacing current limitations, defining criteria, scoring candidates, and verifying each load-bearing factual claim against current public sources.

One candidate can be eliminated up front. **Redash** passed to community maintenance following Databricks' acquisition in 2020, with its latest open-source release (26.3.0) dating to March 2026; no official corporate roadmap for the standalone product has been published, which poses adoption risk for a new deployment.

The remaining three candidates — **Evidence**, **Metabase**, and **Apache Superset** — are all viable, and all three improve on Looker Studio precisely where it is weakest: chart flexibility, calculated fields, access control, and version control. Looker Studio's own strengths (zero cost, zero maintenance, native BigQuery, and ease of use for non-technical staff) are real and are why it was the natural starting point — but they are not the dimensions that triggered this evaluation. The recommended prototype pair is **Metabase and Evidence**, chosen because they represent the two coherent answers to Action4Diabetes' situation rather than two flavours of the same answer: Metabase if non-technical staff will build and edit dashboards directly, Evidence if a small analyst team produces dashboards that everyone else consumes. Superset is held as a runner-up for the scenario where Metabase's chart library proves insufficient against real pipeline output.

2. Background and Current Limitations

Research dashboards are currently built in Looker Studio — Google's free, self-service dashboarding product, not to be confused with the enterprise Looker (full) platform (a separate product, set aside as cost-prohibitive for an NGO and excluded from the comparison). Looker Studio integrates with BigQuery at no infrastructure cost and is free, which makes it an obvious starting point for an NGO. However, the scope identifies four limitations that motivate this evaluation:

- Restricted chart types relative to peer BI tools.
- Poor handling of complex filters, particularly multi-dimensional cross-filtering and dependent filter chains.
- No version control. Dashboards are edited in place with no review process or recovery path.
- Limited support for custom calculations beyond Looker Studio's calculated fields.

User feedback should be collected to confirm and prioritise these (this step is in progress and is out of scope for the present report). The evaluation below assumes all four limitations are real and material; if user research downgrades any of them, the weights in section 3 should be revisited. Because Looker Studio is the tool being replaced, it is scored against the same nine criteria as the candidates in section 5, giving an explicit baseline rather than an implied one.

3. Evaluation Criteria

Eight criteria were taken directly from the internship scope. One was added: **maintenance burden**. For an NGO with rotating interns it is a real factor — the team that patches the server, rotates credentials, and runs version upgrades is the same small team building the dashboards.

- **BigQuery connectivity.** Native connector, authentication patterns, and reliability under load.
- **Chart flexibility.** Breadth of built-in chart types and ease of extending with custom visualisations.
- **Calculated fields.** Power and ergonomics of expressing derived metrics — both ad-hoc and shared across dashboards.
- **Access control.** Authentication, role-based permissions, and row/column-level security for sensitive research data.
- **Cost.** Licence cost plus realistic hosting and operational cost over a 3-year horizon.
- **Version control.** Whether dashboards live in a Git workflow with review, history, and rollback.
- **Embedding.** Ability to embed dashboards in other surfaces (public site, internal portal, partner-facing pages).
- **Ease of use for non-technical staff.** Whether non-developers can read, filter, and ideally build dashboards without analyst help.
- **Maintenance burden** (*added*). Time-cost of keeping the system running: upgrades, security patches, credential rotation, container orchestration.

Scoring uses a 1–5 scale (5 = best fit for Action4Diabetes' context). For cost and maintenance burden, higher scores mean lower cost and lower burden respectively. The unweighted total is shown but should not be read literally; cost realistically operates as a gate rather than just another row, and the relative weighting of ease-of-use vs. version control depends on who will own the dashboards day-to-day.

4. Candidate Tools — Overview

Evidence

Open-source (MIT) framework that treats dashboards as code. Reports are written as Markdown files with embedded SQL; Evidence builds them into a static website. Native BigQuery support. Self-hostable for free (any static-site host); paid Evidence Cloud tier adds managed hosting and team features.

Metabase

Open-source (AGPL v3) BI tool with a strong GUI-first workflow. Native BigQuery connector. Visual query builder lets non-technical users build charts without SQL; SQL questions remain available for analysts. Cloud tiers start at \$100/month + \$6/user/month (Starter); Pro at \$575/month + \$12/user/month adds row-level security, SSO, and embedded analytics. Current stable release 61.2 (May 2026).

Apache Superset

Apache 2.0 licensed, fully open. The most feature-rich open-source option: 40+ chart types, plug-in architecture for custom visualisations, role-based access control with row-level security built in. BigQuery connectivity requires installing the `sqlalchemy-bigquery` driver and configuring a GCP service account. Heavier operationally than Metabase or Evidence.

Redash — *eliminated*

SQL-centric, BSD-2 licensed. Acquired by Databricks in 2020. Latest open-source release is 26.3.0 from March 2026; development has passed to the community following the Databricks acquisition, with no published corporate roadmap for the standalone product. Reviews from 2025–2026 recommend evaluating alternatives for new deployments. Eliminated from further consideration.

Looker Studio — *incumbent baseline*

Google's free, browser-based dashboarding tool (formerly Google Data Studio) and the product Action4Diabetes uses today. Native BigQuery connector, no infrastructure to run, and a drag-and-drop editor that non-technical staff can use without SQL. It is free with no user limits; the optional Looker Studio Pro tier (\$9/user/month) adds team workspaces and governance but is not required for current use. Its weaknesses are the four limitations that prompted this evaluation: a comparatively narrow chart library, a SQL-like-but-not-SQL calculated-field language that runs out of room for complex metrics, no row-level security in the free tier (every viewer sees the same data), and no version control or recovery path. Included here as the baseline every candidate is measured against, not as a candidate.

5. Scoring Matrix

Scores reflect fit for Action4Diabetes specifically, not the tools' absolute capability. Scale: 1–5 (5 = best fit). For **Cost** and **Maintenance burden**, 5 = most affordable / least effort — these two criteria are inverted. Looker Studio is shown first as the incumbent baseline; Redash is scored for completeness but is eliminated (see below) and should not be read as a serious candidate.

Criterion	Looker Studio (current)	Evidence	Metabase	Superset	Redash
BigQuery connectivity	5	5	5	4	4
Chart flexibility	2	3	4	5	2
Calculated fields / SQL	2	5	4	4	4
Access control	2	2	4	4	3
Cost (NGO-affordable)	5	5	4	4	4
Version control	1	5	3*	2	2
Embedding	4	4	4	4	3
Ease of use (non-technical)	5	2	5	3	2
Maintenance burden (low = high score)	5	4	4	2	3
Unweighted total	31	35	37	32	27

* Metabase v61 (Pro/Enterprise) adds dashboards-as-code with remote Git sync; Open Source tier scores 2 for version control. The unweighted total should not be read literally — it sums dimensions of unequal importance, and the four rows that motivated this evaluation matter more than the headline.

Read the baseline column first. Looker Studio's total of **31** is propped up almost entirely by four perfect scores — cost, ease of use, maintenance burden, and BigQuery connectivity — which are exactly the reasons it was the natural starting point for an NGO. But it scores **1–2 on every one of the four dimensions that prompted this review**: chart flexibility, calculated fields, access control, and version control. That is the whole story in one column: the incumbent is cheap, easy, and zero-maintenance, but weak precisely where Action4Diabetes feels pain.

Each viable candidate beats Looker Studio by lifting those weak rows. **Metabase (37)** raises chart flexibility, calculated fields, access control, and version control while keeping ease of use and low maintenance — the smallest sacrifice for the largest gain. **Evidence (35)** transforms version control (1 → 5) and calculated fields (2 → 5) but trades away the ease-of-use that non-technical staff rely on (5 → 2). **Superset (32)** edges past the baseline on capability but costs more operationally (maintenance 5 → 2). **Redash (27)** is the only candidate that does *not* clearly improve on the incumbent and is eliminated on maintenance-status grounds besides.

The detail behind every cell follows next: §6 walks the matrix by criterion (how each tool compares on each row), and §7 walks it by tool (each tool's full story end-to-end).

6. Criterion-by-Criterion Comparison

The scoring matrix above sums to a single number per tool, but the underlying decision lives in the rows, not the totals. This section walks each of the nine criteria in turn — what it measures, how every tool compares on it, and why each score takes the value it does. The companion section that follows (§7) gives the same picture sliced by tool rather than by criterion.

6.1 BigQuery connectivity

What it measures: native connector quality, authentication patterns, and reliability under load. The floor — Action4Diabetes' data lives in BigQuery, so any tool that cannot talk to it cleanly is unusable.

- **Looker Studio — 5.** Native, first-party Google connector with no setup beyond authentication. The path of least resistance, precisely because both products are Google's.
- **Evidence — 5.** BigQuery is among its natively supported sources. Because queries run at build time rather than per page-load, load on BigQuery is also predictable and low.
- **Metabase — 5.** Native BigQuery connector built in. Connects with a service account and works out of the box.
- **Superset — 4.** Capable but not frictionless. Requires installing the `sqlalchemy-bigquery` driver into a custom Docker image and configuring a GCP service-account JSON key. Reliable once set up; the setup itself is the reason for the deduction.
- **Redash — 4.** Connects to BigQuery without problems. The deduction reflects the project's overall maintenance risk rather than the connector itself.

6.2 Chart flexibility

What it measures: breadth of built-in chart types and how easily the library can be extended with custom visualisations. Limitation #1 from the scope.

- **Looker Studio — 2.** Narrow library relative to peer BI tools. Adequate for standard bar, line, table, and scorecard work; the ceiling arrives quickly on anything specialised. A structural product limit, not a configuration gap.
- **Evidence — 3.** A respectable built-in set rendered as a polished website, extensible with custom components, but not aiming to be a deep chart library. Its strength is elsewhere.
- **Metabase — 4.** A broad and well-presented set of common chart types that covers most real dashboard needs, with a clean authoring experience.
- **Superset — 5.** The deepest library in the shortlist by a wide margin: 40+ chart types including treemaps, force-directed graphs, partition charts, geospatial via Mapbox and deck.gl, plus a plug-in API for custom chart types.

- **Redash — 2.** SQL-centric with a comparatively basic visualisation set; charts are an output of queries rather than a rich design surface.

6.3 Calculated fields / SQL

What it measures: how powerfully and ergonomically derived metrics can be expressed — both ad-hoc and shared across dashboards. Limitation #4 from the scope.

- **Looker Studio — 2.** The calculated-field language is SQL-like but not SQL. Functions available in Power BI and in full SQL editors are missing, and complex derived metrics quickly hit a wall.
- **Evidence — 5.** Best in the field. Reports are Markdown with embedded SQL blocks, so the full power of BigQuery's SQL dialect is available with nothing in between.
- **Metabase — 4.** Two-track design: a visual builder for non-technical users and a native SQL editor giving analysts the full BigQuery dialect. The deduction versus Evidence is ergonomic — SQL lives inside "questions" rather than being the native medium.
- **Superset — 4.** Full SQL Lab editor with the complete dialect available; strong, just not code-first in the way Evidence is.
- **Redash — 4.** SQL is its identity; querying is genuinely strong. Redash's problems lie elsewhere.

6.4 Access control

What it measures: authentication, role-based permissions, and row/column-level security for sensitive research data. The operational question — can a country partner be shown only their own rows?

- **Looker Studio — 2.** No row-level security in the free tier — every viewer of a report sees the same data. Scoping rows per partner requires pushing security down into a BigQuery view or paying for governance features.
- **Evidence — 2.** Weakest area in the free self-hosted mode: a static site has no built-in authentication, so dashboards are either public or sit behind whatever the hosting platform provides (Cloudflare Access, Netlify password protection). This 2 reflects the free tier only. Evidence Cloud (Team \$15/user/month, Pro \$25/user/month) adds proper user management and raises this to approximately 4.
- **Metabase — 4.** Group-based read/write permissions on whole dashboards in the free Open Source edition; true row-level security requires the Pro tier at \$575/month. If per-partner row scoping is a hard requirement, this is the cost of entry.
- **Superset — 4.** Unusually strong for open source: enterprise authentication (LDAP, OAuth, OIDC, SAML) and row-level security ship in the *free* Apache distribution, with no paid tier required for the governance Metabase reserves for Pro.
- **Redash — 3.** Group-based access exists; middling but functional.

6.5 Cost (NGO-affordable)

What it measures: licence cost plus realistic hosting and operational cost over a 3-year horizon. Inverted scale — 5 means cheapest.

- **Looker Studio — 5.** Free, with no user limits. The optional Pro tier is \$9/user/month but is not required for current use. Unbeatable on this axis, which is precisely why it is the incumbent.
- **Evidence — 5.** Free to self-host on any static-site host (Netlify, Vercel). Paying applies only when Evidence Cloud is chosen for managed hosting and team features.
- **Metabase — 4.** Free Open Source edition exists; Cloud Starter is \$100/month (5 users included, +\$6/user), Pro is \$575/month (+\$12/user). Very affordable at the low end; the deduction reflects that the features most likely to be needed (RLS) sit behind the \$575 tier.

- **Superset — 4.** The software is free (Apache 2.0), but cost shifts to hosting and operations — multiple containers running continuously cost real money and operator time even when no licence does.
- **Redash — 4.** Free and open source; cost is not Redash's problem.

6.6 Version control

What it measures: whether dashboards live in a Git workflow with review, history, and rollback. Limitation #3 from the scope, and the single lowest score on the entire board.

- **Looker Studio — 1.** The worst score anywhere in the matrix. Dashboards are edited live with no review process, no history, and no recovery path. A bad edit is simply the new state of the dashboard.
- **Evidence — 5.** Its signature strength. A dashboard is a file, so every change is a Git commit; review happens by pull request, rollback is `git revert`. Nothing else in the shortlist matches this — the 1 → 5 swing defines the Evidence case.
- **Metabase — 3 (asterisked).** The Open Source tier scores 2 — edits happen live in the UI by default. Metabase v61 (May 2026) added a dashboards-as-code workflow with remote Git sync on Pro/Enterprise, which earns the 3 shown in the matrix. The gap versus Evidence's native-Git model remains real for teams that want every change reviewed before it goes live.
- **Superset — 2.** Export/import of dashboard definitions as YAML is possible, but it is not a Git-native review workflow.
- **Redash — 2.** Same story — no meaningful version-control workflow.

6.7 Embedding

What it measures: the ability to embed dashboards in other surfaces — public site, internal portal, partner-facing pages.

- **Looker Studio — 4.** Embeds via iframe and public/shareable URLs; serviceable for most embedding needs.
- **Evidence — 4.** Output is a website, so embedding and linking are natural — essentially publishing web pages.
- **Metabase — 4.** Supports embedding; signed/secure embedding and advanced embedded-analytics features live in the Pro tier.
- **Superset — 4.** Embeddable with a supported workflow, on par with the others.
- **Redash — 3.** Embeddable but more limited and less polished.

Embedding scores cluster tightly across the candidates, which is why this row does not differentiate the decision.

6.8 Ease of use (non-technical)

What it measures: whether non-developers can read, filter, and ideally build dashboards without analyst help. This criterion is the swing factor between Metabase and Evidence.

- **Looker Studio — 5.** Drag-and-drop, no SQL required. Non-technical staff can build and read freely. One of the four reasons it was the natural starting point.
- **Evidence — 2.** The hard trade-off. Reading dashboards is easy (polished website), but authoring requires SQL, Markdown, and ideally Git literacy. This 5 → 2 drop is the most consequential cost of choosing Evidence.
- **Metabase — 5.** Matches the incumbent. The visual Question builder lets non-technical staff create charts by selecting tables, columns, and aggregations without SQL, while analysts retain the SQL editor alongside. This is the reason Metabase tops the matrix: it lifts the weak rows without sacrificing ease of use.
- **Superset — 3.** Chart-authoring UI has improved but is still less approachable for non-technical staff than Metabase. Capable hands do well; casual users struggle.
- **Redash — 2.** SQL-first by design; non-technical authoring is not the point of the tool.

6.9 Maintenance burden

What it measures: the time-cost of keeping the system running — upgrades, security patches, credential rotation, container orchestration. The criterion added beyond the scope, because for a small NGO the maintainers and the dashboard-builders are the same people. Inverted scale — 5 means least effort.

- **Looker Studio — 5.** Zero. Google runs everything; no server, no upgrade, no patch. Effortless by construction.
- **Evidence — 4.** Self-hosting a static site is light — there is no live database serving queries — but builds and deploys still need to be managed. Low, not zero.
- **Metabase — 4.** A single Docker container plus a Postgres metadata database; upgrades are usually undramatic and the release cadence is steady. Metabase Cloud removes operational burden entirely for the \$100/month base.
- **Superset — 2.** The heaviest in the shortlist. A real deployment runs multiple containers (web, worker, metadata database, cache, queue), the BigQuery driver must be baked into a custom Docker image, and upgrades are more disruptive. This is the single biggest reason Superset sits at runner-up rather than first.
- **Redash — 3.** Self-hostable and not the heaviest, but the maintenance concern is compounded by community-only maintenance status — patching a tool with no committed maintainer carries its own risk.

6.10 Patterns and one open call

Reading the matrix by criterion surfaces one pattern that is not visible in the totals alone, plus one judgment call worth making consciously rather than by default:

- **Evidence (35) and Metabase (37) finish close on the headline but reach the answer in opposite ways.** Evidence wins version control and calculated fields outright (5/5) and loses ease of use (5 → 2); Metabase wins ease of use (5) and trails on version control (3). This is not noise — it is the actual decision, and it maps directly to who will build the dashboards (see §9).
- **The access-control score for Looker Studio (2) is the one soft number in the table.** It reflects the lack of native row-level security in the free tier. If Action4Diabetes routinely pushes RLS down into a BigQuery view, that mechanism works under Looker Studio, Evidence, and Metabase alike — which would argue for raising the incumbent to a 3 and would compress the access-control row as a differentiator across the table. The decision should be made consciously rather than left to default.

7. Detailed Tool Assessment

7.1 Evidence

Evidence's defining choice is to treat dashboards as code. A report is a Markdown file with SQL blocks embedded inline; the tool compiles the Markdown into a static website with charts rendered at build time. This has three meaningful consequences for Action4Diabetes:

- **Version control is native, not bolted on.** Every change is a Git commit. Pull requests review proposed dashboard changes the way they review code. Rollback is `git revert`. None of the alternatives match this.
- **Build-time queries mean fast, cheap dashboards.** Queries run when the site is built, not when a user loads a page. For research dashboards that update on a known cadence (daily or weekly), this is a strong fit and keeps BigQuery costs predictable.
- **Non-technical users cannot author dashboards.** This is the trade-off. Reading dashboards is fine — Evidence produces a polished website. But authoring requires SQL, Markdown, and ideally Git literacy. This is the most consequential constraint to weigh.

Access control is Evidence's weakest area in the free self-hosted mode: a static site has no built-in authentication, so dashboards are either public or sit behind whatever the hosting platform provides (e.g. Cloudflare Access, Netlify

password protection). Evidence Cloud's paid tier adds proper user management (Team plan \$15/user/month, Pro plan \$25/user/month) and is worth pricing if access control matters. The access control score of 2 in §5 reflects the self-hosted free tier only; Evidence Cloud raises this to approximately 4.

7.2 Metabase

Metabase is the strongest all-rounder for an NGO context. The visual Question builder lets non-technical staff create charts by selecting tables and columns and choosing aggregations, without writing SQL. The native SQL editor is available alongside for analysts who want the full power of BigQuery's SQL dialect.

Three points worth flagging specifically:

- **Version control is weaker than Evidence, but improving.** Metabase v61 added a dashboards-as-code workflow with remote Git sync, available on Pro/Enterprise. In practice, dashboard edits still happen live in the UI by default, so the gap versus Evidence's native-Git model remains real for teams that want every change reviewed before it goes live. The score of 3 shown in §5 reflects the Pro/Enterprise tier with the v61 Git-sync workflow; the Open Source tier would score 2.
- **Row-level security requires Pro.** If Action4Diabetes needs to scope rows by user (e.g., country-level partners seeing only their own data), the Pro tier at \$575/month is the minimum. Group-based read/write permissions on full dashboards are available in the free Open Source edition.
- **Deployment is light.** A single Docker container plus a PostgreSQL metadata database. Upgrades are usually undramatic; the project's release pace is steady. Metabase Cloud removes operational burden entirely for \$100/month base on the Starter tier.

7.3 Apache Superset

Superset has the deepest visualisation library of any tool in the shortlist — treemaps, force-directed graphs, partition charts, geospatial via Mapbox and deck.gl, and a plug-in API for custom chart types beyond Metabase's built-in set. If the research dashboards need a chart type that does not exist in Metabase, Superset is the answer. Enterprise-grade authentication (LDAP, OAuth, OIDC, SAML) and row-level security ship in the free Apache distribution, which is unusual for an open-source BI tool.

The cost is operational. Superset deployment involves multiple containers (web, worker, metadata database, cache, queue), the BigQuery driver must be installed into a custom Docker image, and upgrades are more disruptive than Metabase's. The chart-authoring UI has been improving but is still less approachable for non-technical staff than Metabase. The right read for Action4Diabetes: keep Superset as a contingency if the Metabase prototype reveals a chart-flexibility gap.

7.4 Redash (eliminated)

Redash remains technically functional and connects to BigQuery, but the project is now community-maintained with no corporate sponsor following the Databricks acquisition. Without a committed maintainer, the risk profile is unchanged: a CVE in a dependency could force an emergency migration on the team's least convenient schedule.

7.5 Looker Studio (incumbent baseline)

Looker Studio is the tool to beat, and on three dimensions it is genuinely hard to beat. It is free with no user limits, it requires zero infrastructure or maintenance (Google runs it entirely), and its drag-and-drop editor lets non-technical staff build and read dashboards without touching SQL. Its BigQuery connector is native. For an NGO, that combination is exactly why it was the obvious starting point, and any replacement has to justify giving some of it up.

The case for moving rests on the four limitations from section 2, all of which the scoring confirms. Chart flexibility is narrow relative to peer BI tools. The calculated-field language is SQL-like but not SQL — it lacks functions that Power BI and full SQL editors provide, and complex derived metrics quickly hit a wall. The free tier has no row-level security, so every viewer of a report sees the same data; scoping rows per partner requires pushing security down into a BigQuery view or paying for governance features. And there is no version control or recovery path: reports are

edited live, with no review, history, or rollback — the single dimension where Looker Studio scores worst (1/5) and where Evidence's Git-native model is the sharpest contrast. Looker Studio Pro (\$9/user/month, billed per Google Cloud project) adds team workspaces and some governance but does not close the chart, calculated-field, or version-control gaps. The recommendation is therefore not that Looker Studio is bad — it is that the specific pains driving this evaluation are structural to the product, and the viable candidates resolve them.

8. Verification Methodology

Tool capabilities, pricing, and release status change between AI training cutoffs and the present. Every load-bearing factual claim in the scoring matrix and detailed assessments was therefore verified against current public sources (vendor pricing pages, vendor documentation, vendor changelogs, GitHub releases, and recent independent re-views from 2025–2026). Findings that did not match initial estimates were corrected before the final scores were assigned. The table below summarises what was checked.

Claim	Initial estimate	Verified finding	Status
Looker Studio cost (in-cumbent)	Free; Pro tier exists	Confirmed. Free tier has no user limits and no paid gate; viewers need no licence. Looker Studio Pro is \$9/user/month, billed per Google Cloud project (not per organisation).	Confirmed
Looker Studio limitations (charts, calc fields, RLS, version control)	Four limitations from scope	Confirmed against 2026 sources. SQL-like (not SQL) calculated fields; no row-level security in free tier (all viewers see same data); no version control / recovery path; chart library narrower than peer BI tools.	Confirmed
Looker (full) ≠ Looker Studio	Same product family	Confirmed they are separate products. Looker (full) base ~\$60K/yr (AWS Marketplace), so excluded from the comparison as cost-prohibitive for an NGO; not the tool in current use.	Confirmed
Redash development status	Pace slowed post-Databricks	Community-maintained with no corporate sponsor following Databricks acquisition. Latest OSS release 26.3.0 from March 2026. Reviews recommend evaluating alternatives for new deployments.	Corrected
Metabase active development	Actively developed	Confirmed. Current stable release 61.2 (May 19, 2026). Regular release cadence.	Confirmed
Metabase paid tier pricing	Free OSS, paid Pro for advanced features	Open Source (free, AGPL v3); Starter \$100/mo + \$6/user/mo; Pro \$575/mo + \$12/user/mo; Enterprise ~\$20K/yr+.	Refined
Apache Superset chart count	40+ chart types	Confirmed (Superset.apache.org). Plug-in architecture supports custom visualisations. Current stable Superset 6.1.0 (May 2026).	Corrected
Superset BigQuery setup complexity	Requires service account JSON + SQLAlchemy	Confirmed. Requires installing <code>sqlalchemy-bigquery</code> driver in custom Docker image + GCP service account JSON key.	Confirmed
Evidence.dev active development & BigQuery	Active; native BQ connector	Confirmed. MIT licensed; active changelog through Jan 2026; BigQuery one of the natively supported sources.	Confirmed
Metabase row-level security	Available in paid tier	Confirmed. Row-level permissions require Pro tier (\$575/mo + per-user). Open Source has group-based access only.	Confirmed

One correction materially changed the candidate set: the Redash sunset finding moved it from "low-priority candidate" to "eliminated". Verifying Looker Studio's own capabilities confirmed all four scope limitations against current sources, which is what anchors the baseline column in section 5. The remaining checks confirmed initial estimates or refined them with specific numbers.

9. Recommendation

All three viable candidates score above the Looker Studio baseline (31) by improving the four dimensions that motivated this review. The recommendation narrows that field to a prototype of two tools — **Metabase** and **Evidence** — run against real BigQuery pipeline output. These two are recommended together rather than as a ranked first/second because the choice between them depends on a decision Action4Diabetes should make explicitly, not on tool capability alone:

- **If non-technical staff will build and edit dashboards**, Metabase is the right answer. The visual Question builder is materially easier than any other tool in the shortlist for someone who does not write SQL. Accept the trade-off of weaker version control.
- **If a small analyst team will produce dashboards that everyone else consumes**, Evidence is the right answer. Native Git workflow, fast static-site dashboards, and predictable BigQuery costs. Accept that non-technical authoring is off the table.

A reasonable hybrid is also possible: Evidence for the small set of "official" research dashboards that benefit from review and history, Metabase for exploratory and ad-hoc work. This costs more operationally (two tools to run) but matches the two-audience reality of most research organisations.

Apache Superset is held as a runner-up. If the Metabase prototype reveals a chart-flexibility gap that cannot be closed (Superset's library extends further with partition charts, force-directed graphs, deck.gl geospatial, and a plugin API for custom chart types), Superset is the upgrade path. Bringing it in later is reasonable; starting with it now would over-pay in setup cost.

10. Next Steps — Prototype Plan

The prototype phase has four discrete pieces:

1. Choose one representative existing Looker Studio dashboard as the rebuild target. Aim for one that exercises at least two of the four identified limitations (complex filters or custom calculations are the most informative).
2. Stand up Metabase (Cloud Starter, ~\$100/month, no infrastructure required) and Evidence (free self-host on Netlify or Vercel). Connect both to a read-only BigQuery service account.
3. Rebuild the chosen dashboard in each. Track time-to-first-result, time-to-feature-parity, and any gaps where the tool cannot match what Looker Studio does today.
4. Demo both prototypes to the same set of intended users (technical and non-technical) and collect structured feedback. The feedback, not the scoring matrix, is what determines the final choice.

A two-week prototype window is realistic. Cost during the prototype period is at most ~\$200 (one month of Metabase Cloud Starter for both users plus a few dollars of BigQuery query cost); Evidence is free to host. Budget approval for the prototype phase should therefore not be a blocker.

Appendix: Sources

Pricing and feature claims in this report were verified against the following types of sources during preparation:

- **Vendor pricing pages:** lookerstudio.google.com (free tier and Pro at \$9/user/month), metabase.com/pricing, evidence.dev/pricing

- **Vendor documentation and changelogs:** docs.evidence.dev/changelog, superset.apache.org, docs.meta-base.com, Looker Studio Help Center
- **GitHub releases:** github.com/getredash/redash (latest 26.3.0, March 2026)
- **Independent 2025–2026 reviews:** Looker Studio capability and limitation write-ups (CheckThat.ai, Valiotti, Windsor.ai), Coefficient and CheckThat.ai pricing breakdowns, Elestio Superset-vs-Metabase-vs-Redash 2026 comparison

Specific facts (Metabase release 61.2 dated May 19, 2026; Redash community-maintenance status; Looker Studio free-tier limitations and \$9/user/month Pro pricing; the distinction between Looker Studio and the enterprise Looker platform) are cited inline in the corresponding section.